

South London College career and course finder

Research and product blueprint for the course development team and developers

Prepared 9 September 2026. Research checked 8 September 2026.

Recommended service

Build one service with two starting choices: **Explore career ideas** and **Find a course**. Use a shared question engine and results page so learners can move from a career direction to courses without repeating equivalent answers. Keep direct course search and adviser contact available. The primary outcome is an understandable, feasible next step. Enrolment follows that decision.

The first route asks six original questions about goals, activities, priorities, preferred daily tasks, relevant experience and the next step the learner wants. The second asks five about course purpose, subject, relevant experience, weekly study time and total-price preference. Time and price questions can be skipped. Allow at most one optional clarification before results. Specific admission checks appear when a learner inspects a course; they are visibly separate from the short exploration journey.

Use two page templates: a question page and a results page. A sequence of short screens inside the question page keeps the experience manageable on a phone. Do not put eleven questions on one scrolling form, or make a learner complete both routes. Target 2-3 minutes for career exploration and 1-2 minutes for course finding, but publish timing claims only after testing them.

Position it as a **career and course guide**. A few preference questions cannot establish aptitude, personality, eligibility, the right career, or a probability of employment. Present up to three explained options, make uncertainty visible, and offer a useful next action. Career exploration must remain broader than SLC's available courses.

For launch, use reviewed rules to select courses and templates to explain them. Add AI only where testing shows that it improves understanding, such as explaining differences or answering a question using approved facts. The finder must remain useful with AI switched off.

This package specifies the product and provides a reference engine and interactive concept. Production integration, verified course content, human evaluation and operational launch checks remain development work. There is no evidence yet that this design improves SLC conversion or learner outcomes.

What the UK evidence changes

Learning and Work Institute's 2025 survey covered 5,186 UK adults aged 17 and over. Among current or recent learners, 28% reported time pressure, 19% cost and 19% confidence challenges. Among adults with no learning in the previous three years, 24% cited cost and 10% not finding a suitable course. These are different respondent bases and include informal learning, not only paid online qualifications. The design implication is to explain workload, cost and support alongside subject relevance. [S1]

Jisc's 2024/25 FE digital experience survey received 5,881 responses at 16 organisations. Respondents valued flexibility and access, while 45% reported lacking a suitable device and 59% wifi problems. This participating-provider sample is not representative of SLC prospects. It supports a fast, accessible mobile finder and clear equipment requirements before enrolment; it does not establish that every course can be completed on a phone. [S2]

DfE qualitative research into adult learning decisions found that practical information becomes especially important near enrolment: workload, assignments, prerequisites, format and support. Its 2018 study involved 70 learners and 16 non-learners. A separate 2021 study of adults below Level 2 identified career, family and personal-development motivations, alongside time, cost and support barriers. These older studies explain possible decision mechanisms, not current population percentages. [S3, S4]

Nesta's evaluation of 11 CareerTech online-learning innovations supports clearer course information, relevant learning, deliberate onboarding and sensitive human support. It does not prove that adding AI increases enrolment. DfE's Flexible Learning Fund evaluation also shows why flexibility needs explanation: timing, pace and place are different, and unrestricted timelines can create completion problems. [S5, S6]

These sources support a practical guide, but do not establish SLC's traffic sources, device mix, willingness to pay, ideal number of questions or reaction to an email gate. Three results, immediate access and optional previews are testable design choices. Gather SLC evidence before calling any of them a conversion improvement.

Learner needs and decision behaviour

Segment by the decision a learner needs to make. Avoid assigning a personality or ambition level from age, gender, employment status or education. A graduate can be a beginner in a new field; an experienced worker can lack a formal qualification.

Learner situation	What they need to resolve	What the guide should do
Exploring a first direction	What different work actually involves	Use everyday activities, concrete role examples and a small next step
Changing field	Which experience transfers and what needs learning	Ask about the chosen subject and show requirements separately
Returning to learning	Whether study feels manageable	Explain assessment, support, workload and a genuine sample task
Progressing at work	Whether a qualification serves a specific goal	Ask for an exact requirement and verify it before matching
Managing limited time or money	Whether a course fits real constraints	Compare total price, access window, deadlines and practical commitments
Already knows the course	Whether this is the exact award and delivery they need	Bypass the quiz and provide direct search and comparison

The proposed decision sequence is: recognise a relevant goal, recognise an interesting activity, understand the options, check feasibility, inspect the course, then enrol or ask for advice. This is a product model to validate, not an observed SLC funnel.

Make each click useful. An answer should change the result, resolve a condition or personalise the next action. Use "I'm not sure" as a valid answer. Prefer "What would you like to try?" to "What are you naturally good at?" for beginners. Asking about unfamiliar professional tasks can measure exposure rather than interest.

Show why an option appeared using the learner's selections. Give a concrete task and one thing to investigate. Avoid a long sales pitch, false urgency, inflated salary headlines and prestige-driven recommendations. Human advice is a successful outcome when it resolves uncertainty.

Benchmarks and industry patterns

Public pages and published method descriptions were inspected. Authenticated assessments were not completed, and advertised times are publisher estimates. The supplied six-page Coursera screenshot was visually reviewed in full. [S7-S13]

Service	Published effort and approach	What SLC should take from it
Coursera career quiz	20 questions, 5-10 minutes, six professional domains and learning paths	Link exploration to learning, but use beginner language and avoid copying aptitude claims
National Careers Service	40 questions, 5-10 minutes, interests and self-reported strengths, comparison and advice	Reassurance, multiple options and access to an adviser
Prospects	Career Planner and Job Match; public page describes under 10 minutes for Job Match and sign-in	Career groups and comparison; test optional saving after results
UCAS	Adviser documentation describes 30 questions with career, course and labour-market links	Explain daily work and pathways; published method may differ from current public interface
O*NET Interest Profiler	Online Mini-IP has 30 items; documented instrument research	Evidence standard for a validated assessment; US facts require UK interpretation
DfE Get to an answer	Branching guidance pattern recommending no more than 10 questions	Strong fit for a short information guide; explicitly separate eligibility

The most applicable patterns are guided discovery, progressive detail, explainable recommendations, human handoff and practical information. These are observed service patterns, not proof of adoption growth or commercial performance. Longer validated instruments can be offered as external options; a six-question SLC guide does not inherit their validation.

GOV.UK recommends starting with one question per page, avoiding repeated questions, supporting Back and allowing uncertainty where meaningful. Test the progress indicator and question sequence with real learners. [S13]

What the course map tells us

The July 2026 workbook is a useful taxonomy seed. The master sheet contains **395 rows, 394 distinct course URLs and 388 distinct titles**. It has 16 primary categories and 115 rows also listed elsewhere. These counts describe the attachment, not the complete live portfolio. Reconcile it with the stated 500+ courses before claiming full coverage.

There are **109 rows labelled QLS** and 286 carrying other awarding-body labels. These are source labels, not a completed regulatory audit. QLS explains that its endorsed courses are non-regulated provision; they must not be described as Ofqual-regulated qualifications. A course naming a regulated awarding organisation still needs a course-specific qualification-number check. [S14, S15]

Data issue	Evidence	Required treatment
Conflicting identity	Master rows 205 and 206 share the ATHE business-management URL but name ATHE and Focus Awards	Preserve both records in staging; resolve before publishing
Missing level	Master row 11 has an incomplete business-administration title and blank level	Mark unknown and ask the content owner to verify
Duplicate titles	395 rows but 388 distinct titles	Do not deduplicate by title; awards and providers can differ
Missing decision facts	No structured price, entry, placement, TQT or active-status fields	Enrich from owned systems and approved evidence
Snapshot coverage	July source contains fewer entries than the stated portfolio	Reconcile active, new, withdrawn and bundled offers

The primary-category counts sum to 395: Business and Management 98; Health and Social Care 65; Information Technology 54; Teaching and Education 44; Science and Engineering 24; Childcare 23; Sports and Fitness 23; Accounting and Finance 13; Animal Care 10; Law 8; Hospitality Management 7; Human Resources 7; Marketing 7; Coaching and Mentoring 5; Employability Skills 4; Beauty, Hair and Wellbeing 3. These are primary assignments, so they differ from totals that include cross-listings.

The exported staging data preserves all rows and their provenance. It is deliberately not a production recommendation catalogue. Course owners must approve a publishable set. Start with approximately 30-50 thoroughly reviewed courses across the main learner needs if the full catalogue cannot be checked in time; disclose that initial coverage and keep normal catalogue browsing available.

Two page learner experience

Page one: questions. Open with "What would you like help with?" and two clear actions: "Explore career ideas" and "Find a course". Add a quieter "Browse all courses" link. Introductory copy: "There are no right answers. Choose what interests you, even if you have never tried it. You can change your answers." No account, email or telephone is needed.

Show one clear question at a time. For multiselects, say "Choose up to two"; selecting uncertainty clears other choices and vice versa. Use native controls, explicit Continue, Back, visible selection and a short progress label. Never auto-advance after an answer. Preserve answers when going Back. Avoid setting sensitive answers in URLs or analytics.

Page two: results. Career results show up to three directions. Each has "Why this appeared", one everyday activity, one practical issue to investigate and a next step. "Find courses for this direction" opens the course route with equivalent earlier answers reused. A course result shows up to three distinct options, not three near-identical awards. Let learners change answers, refine time or price, and inspect requirements.

Keep the first view concise: title, relevance explanation, credential type, verified total price, study expectation and the most important entry or placement check. Expand assessment, detailed support, equipment, payment terms and progression on demand. Show total payable price and required extra charges together; a monthly instalment is not the full cost. Use "View course and entry requirements" as the primary action until checks support the next step.

Show results without a lead gate. Afterwards offer an optional email copy or adviser contact. Ask only for the chosen contact channel. Let learners decide whether to share their answer summary with an adviser. Use a separate unticked marketing choice, not an implied subscription.

No-match copy: "We haven't found a verified course that fits these choices yet. You can change a preference, browse related subjects or talk to an adviser." If a career lies outside SLC's coverage, explain that and link to an appropriate independent source.

Career questionnaire

These original questions guide exploration. The exact answer IDs, limits, skip rules and reuse conditions are in questionnaire.json. Uncertainty and exploration choices are available throughout, and none of these questions is an aptitude assessment.

C1 What would you like your next step to help you do? Choose one: get started in work; move into different work; progress in current work; return after a break; learn for personal interest; explore before deciding. Use it for the next action, not ability or level.

C2 Which activities would you most like to try? Choose up to two: support someone; help someone learn; organise tasks; find patterns and solve problems; make or improve something practical; create ideas, designs or stories; explain ideas and help people choose; work with animals, nature or the environment; not sure. These are interest signals, including activities outside SLC's coverage.

C3 What would matter most to you in your work? Choose up to two: make a difference; clear routine; variety; opportunities to progress; creativity; fit around other commitments; still working this out. Use these as comparison prompts. A priority does not establish that an occupation offers flexibility, security or progression.

C4 What would you like more of in a typical working day? Choose up to two: talking with people; focus on own tasks; practical activity; information or digital tools; a mix; not sure. Refine activity preferences without assigning a fixed personality or learning style.

C5 How much experience do you have in the areas that interest you? Choose one: starting from the beginning; related everyday or volunteering experience; related study; related work; both study and work; not sure what counts. Never convert this directly into an RQF level or assume study means a completed qualification.

C6 How would you like to start exploring this? Choose one: try a small activity; introductory course; compare qualifications; build on existing learning; talk it through; not sure. This chooses the next action. A preference for a small first step should not remove an ambitious longer-term direction.

Optional C7. If supported directions are tied, show two educator-written practical scenarios with Both, Neither and Not sure. Do not ask it when it would not change the result. The model must not invent scored questions during a session.

Example result: "Care and support is worth exploring because you selected helping someone and practical activity. A care worker may help with everyday routines. Check the actual role's personal-care tasks and shift pattern. Explore the role, try a short introductory activity, or compare suitable training." This is exploration, not a claim that a course or person meets job requirements. [S27]

Course questionnaire

F1 What would you like this course to help you do? Choose one: start a new subject; prepare for a first job or career change; develop skills for current work; progress to further study; meet a specific employer or professional requirement; learn for personal interest; not sure. When the requirement is specific, offer an explicitly optional exact-name field or adviser route. Never substitute a merely related course for a required award.

F2 What would you like to study? Use the 16 verified subject categories, searchable by ordinary words and exact course names, plus "Help me explore". Permit a changeable subject suggestion from a selected career direction. Search aliases are editorially maintained. A phrase outside the taxonomy should prompt clarification or external guidance, not force the nearest commercial result.

F3 What have you already done in this subject? Choose one: new to it; informal or practical experience; completed a related course or qualification; use the skills at work; both related qualification and work experience; not sure. An optional qualification-name field is separate. Reuse C5 only where the meaning is equivalent and subject is unchanged.

F4 How much time could you usually set aside for study each week? Optional: less than 2 hours; 2-4; 5-8; 9 or more; varies or not sure. Treat a range as a range. It is a planning preference, not proof of capacity. Do not turn guided learning hours alone into a completion date. Distinguish total qualification time, access period, placement hours and fixed deadlines.

F5 Would you like to set a maximum total course price? Optional: show all prices; enter an amount in pounds; understand payment options first. Reveal the amount field only if requested. It is an extra input within an optional price question. Accept zero as a real budget; blank means unknown. Do not treat unavailable prices as free or affordable.

Optional F6. Ask one relevant course-specific check only when it changes the shortlist, such as access to a required placement. Include Yes, No and Not sure. If several conditions need evidence, keep the course in "Entry requirements to check" and offer a clearly labelled requirements panel or adviser contact. Do not hide an admissions interview inside a supposedly five-question quiz.

On results, provide an optional "Regulated qualifications only" filter with an explanation of the distinction. A named professional or employer requirement takes precedence. Minimum age, exact prior awards, English-language requirements, workplace arrangements and country of intended use require reviewed course-specific checks.

Results that support a decision

For each recommended course show the exact title, awarding organisation, verified qualification type and level. Include a qualification number and official evidence link where applicable. Explain that a level describes difficulty; it does not establish duration, a whole degree or suitability for every novice. A Level 7 diploma is not automatically a master's degree. [S15, S16]

Show a concise answer-linked reason, what the learner can learn, the practical requirements, cost and study expectations. Separate three entry states: **Appears to meet the listed checks**, **Entry requirements to check**, and **Another step is needed first**. These describe information supplied; formal admission remains separate.

Do not show a future progression option as an immediately suitable course. Explain the unmet requirement and a verified route where one exists. If there is no approved route, offer advice. A regulated qualification does not automatically confer professional registration or qualify someone for every job listed in a marketing page. [S17]

Two live SLC examples show why facts need structure. The Level 2 Certificate Introducing Caring for Children and Young People page has conflicting age wording: prerequisites describe over 14, while the FAQ describes 16 or over. That rule needs owner review. The IT diploma page distinguishes 600 total qualification hours from 300 guided hours and advertises different programme and access durations. Keep those fields separate. These examples were checked on 8 September 2026 and are not full qualification audits. [S18, S19]

For a simple study-planning illustration, 600 total hours at 5 hours a week is about 120 weeks before allowance for individual pace, breaks or scheduling. At 10 hours a week it is about 60 weeks. Those calculations do not establish completion dates or fit within a provider's access window. Avoid promising "study at your pace" without explaining the limits.

Career cards should use dated, approved role facts from National Careers Service or the relevant professional body. Show routes such as apprenticeship, employer training or further study where supported; a paid SLC course need not be the first step. Salary or vacancy content should be omitted from the first release unless its scope, geography, freshness, licence and presentation can be maintained.

Matching and the role of AI

Career exploration and course matching use different logic. Career suggestions come from a reviewed activity-to-family map, not the stock of courses. Course matching begins after a subject or direction is selected. A college course title alone is not evidence of an occupation pathway.

For the proposed career map, give two points for an explicit C2 activity association and one for a compatible C4 daily-work preference. Divide activity contributions equally between selected activities so picking two does not double certainty. Require an explicit activity signal for a ranked result. Use C3 for "things to check" and C1, C5, C6 for next-step wording; none measures ability. Keep positive ties visible and invite one clarification. These weights are editable design assumptions, not a validated test.

For courses, first exclude records that are inactive, unapproved, conflicting or expired in critical facts. Evaluate reviewed entry rules separately using true, false and unknown. Then calculate internal relevance from subject 40, purpose 25, relevant experience 15, workload 10 and budget 10. These are starter weights for review. Unknown learner preferences are omitted from one request-wide internal denominator shared by all candidates; unknown course facts earn no credit and produce warnings. A stated maximum total budget excludes verified all-inclusive prices above the cap. Unknown prices remain a check, never an affordability claim. Never display the internal score as a match percentage. The reference implementation defines exact behaviour and edge cases.

Require a positive subject or substantive goal signal. All-unknown requests lead to clarification. Do not fill three result slots with weak unrelated options. Apply the same rules to identical relevant inputs; no margin, commission, protected-characteristic or marketing-consent input may affect relevance. Eligibility mismatch remains separate even if relevance is high.

AI can simplify approved explanations or compare selected courses. It cannot change order, admission state, factual numbers, URLs or qualification claims. Give it only the minimal answer codes and approved evidence for selected IDs. Treat imported descriptions as untrusted data. Validate output shape and IDs; render facts from structured data and use bounded language templates where claim checking cannot be made reliable. On errors, timeouts or unsupported claims, show the complete template explanation.

Before enabling AI, compare it against templates in a blinded learner study. Require no unsupported factual claims in the approved test set, stable course IDs and entry states, acceptable readability, and a measurable benefit to comprehension. A grounded model can still make mistakes; retrieval alone is not a guarantee.

Course data and editorial operation

Use an **SLC-owned CMS export or API plus a reviewed qualification and requirements layer**. The July workbook seeds categories, source links and migration reconciliation. Developers should first confirm the live platform and available identifiers. This research has not authenticated to SLC's systems or verified its CMS integration capabilities.

The import flow is: pull current identity, availability and commercial fields; preserve the raw source; validate schema and duplicates; compare changes; route conflicts to owners; check qualifications and requirements; approve a versioned release; publish atomically; retain the previous release for rollback. A scrape may detect drift but must not silently overwrite approved facts.

Separate a course delivery offer from its qualification. One qualification may have several delivery plans, prices or providers. Store canonical course ID, qualification ID, category membership, plans and requirements separately. Each decision field needs value, status, source, checked date, reviewer and next review date. Unknown, not applicable, conflicting and false are distinct.

Required launch facts include current availability and URL; exact award and framework; regulation/endorsement evidence; complete entry rules including alternatives; assessment and practical commitments; total payable cost and required extras; TQT/GLH where applicable; realistic schedule and access window; equipment and language requirements; and the actual support offer. Career links need relation type and evidence: introductory learning, skill development, progression or part of a professional route.

Proposed operation: nightly changes from owned systems, urgent withdrawals published immediately, weekly exception review during pilot and monthly review of unresolved issues afterwards. Define expiry by field: commercial/availability facts generally need more frequent checks than stable curriculum. The content owner must set achievable service levels rather than let the software invent freshness.

Quarantine the conflicting business diploma rows. Preserve the missing-level row without inferring a value from its URL. The staging export has a unique import-row identifier plus a shared URL-group identifier so a conflict is visible. Production IDs must come from the owned system, not titles or row positions.

Hosting and integration

Recommend a small application with the frontend and API in one Docker image, a reviewed catalogue loaded into memory, and no learner database for ordinary anonymous recommendations. An existing supported web framework is sufficient; pin maintained versions when implementation starts. A 500-course catalogue does not require a vector database. Add a database only for editorial workflow, saved results or reliable contact delivery.

AWS production option: use SLC's account in London, eu-west-2. Store the image in ECR and run ECS on Fargate behind HTTPS, with a managed certificate, appropriate network controls, redacted monitoring and Secrets Manager. ECS Express Mode can provision the service infrastructure; choose one infrastructure owner. Versioned private S3 can hold approved catalogue releases. Add private RDS PostgreSQL if persistence is needed, with backups and tested restore. [S20, S21]

Railway pilot alternative: deploy the same image using its supplied PORT and a readiness endpoint. Its documented European deployment location is Amsterdam, not a UK region. Record actual data flows and subprocessors before selection. Railway deployment healthchecks do not replace continuous uptime monitoring. If using PostgreSQL, enable appropriate backups and test recovery. [S22-S24]

Do not specify AWS App Runner for a new customer: AWS stopped accepting new customers on 30 April 2026. [S25]

For SLC integration, prefer a dedicated hostname or an agreed reverse-proxied path with the same visual identity. Avoid an iframe unless the team has resolved mobile height, focus, navigation and analytics ownership. Link from the main course navigation, subject pages, unsuccessful searches and relevant course pages. Retain the existing checkout and admissions process.

Estimate infrastructure with the selected availability, traffic and persistence requirements. Include load balancer, database, logging, backup and network costs as well as compute. AI cost equals explanation requests times measured average token usage and the selected provider's current rates. Budget caps and a model-off switch are required. No provider price quotation or production deployment has been made in this package.

Privacy accessibility and trust

Give useful results without identification. Ordinary answers can remain transient. If saving is offered, use an expiring random token and minimal answer codes; keep personal answers out of URLs, session replay and logs. A proposed 30-day save window is an operational choice for review, not a statutory rule. Separate requested results delivery, adviser contact, marketing and analytics purposes. Record the appropriate lawful basis and retention for each. [S26]

An email copy is a requested service, not blanket marketing permission. Use a separate unticked marketing choice with a clear withdrawal route and consent record. A quiz completion does not automatically satisfy a marketing soft opt-in. Classify analytics: advertising and non-exempt tracking need valid consent. The current PECR statistical exception is narrow and requires clear information and a simple free objection mechanism; it does not cover advertising or individual profiling. [S28, S29]

Map AI, hosting, backups, support access, email and CRM data flows. Region choice alone does not settle UK data protection. Assess DPIA requirements and document the decision. The service is guidance, but any later use for admissions, credit or employment changes the risk and legal assessment. Assess likely child access: an adult focus alone does not exclude school leavers or settle Children's Code applicability. [S26, S30, S31]

Target WCAG 2.2 AA. Use labelled native controls, logical headings, visible keyboard focus, accessible errors, screen-reader announcements on step changes, explicit Continue, Back without data loss, readable contrast and no colour-only meaning. Test at 320 CSS pixels and 200% text zoom. Use roughly 44-pixel answer targets as a product choice; the AA minimum target criterion has different thresholds and exceptions. Avoid focus-obscuring banners. [S32]

Explain the recommendation method in one accessible link. Publish the scope of covered courses, update approach and contact route for incorrect facts. Make commercial ownership clear: "Career ideas are for exploration. Course suggestions are from South London College." Do not call the career output independent advice if it is restricted to college offerings.

Marketing and measurement

Use the finder as useful guidance across SLC's existing journey. Place a contextual entry beside subject browsing and search, and offer it on no-results pages. Paid campaigns can deep-link to a subject or purpose only when the landing experience states and lets the learner change that context. Campaign labels must not covertly alter recommendations.

Publish accessible explanatory entry content around choosing courses and understanding qualification types. Keep personalised result pages out of search indexes and shared URLs free of answers. Do not auto-generate hundreds of thin AI career pages or make unsupported job, salary or qualification claims. Confirm rights before reusing external career content.

Measure	Definition	What it tells the team
Completion	Result views divided by valid journey starts	Friction; inspect route and question drop-off
Decision clarity	Respondents agreeing they understand their next step divided by feedback respondents	Report response rate and selection bias
Suitability	Adviser-approved shortlists divided by reviewed shortlists	Whether recommendations are defensible
Course engagement	Sessions opening a recommended course divided by result sessions	Interest after guidance; not proof of enrolment quality
Enrolment	Attributed enrolments divided by eligible result sessions under an agreed attribution policy	Commercial contribution; observe consent limitations
Downstream fit	Early course changes or cancellations divided by attributed enrolments	Whether exciting recommendations created poor fit

Measure time-to-result and adviser contacts alongside these. Record aggregate events such as `journey_started`, `question_completed`, `results_viewed`, `course_opened`, `adviser_requested` and `clarity_feedback`. Allow only a small defined property set such as route and content version. Never put answers, email, free text or sensitive inferred career interests into ad pixels or ordinary analytics.

Test guided discovery against current search first. Then test explanation/shortlist design, then AI against templates. Choose one primary outcome and a minimum meaningful effect before each test; calculate sample size from SLC baseline rates and traffic. Do not pick a duration simply because two weeks sounds convenient. Keep suitability and cancellation measures as guardrails.

Build sequence and acceptance

An indicative delivery plan is six to eight weeks with a product/content owner, one or two developers, design support and part-time QA/privacy review. This is a planning estimate, not a commitment. Catalogue cleanup and access to systems are likely dependencies.

Phase	Concrete output	Exit condition
Discovery and data audit	Current portfolio reconciliation, 12-15 learner interviews, enquiry/cancellation themes	Clear user needs, content owner and initial covered set
Content and prototype	Approved questions, role mappings, first course records, interactive flow	8-12 moderated sessions can explain options and next steps
Build and integrate	Question UI, reference rules adapted, catalogue importer, optional contact integration	Functional tests, no-match and failure paths pass
Validate and pilot	Adviser-labelled test set, accessibility checks, privacy and security review	No unresolved critical suitability or factual defect
Release and learn	Limited rollout, monitoring, rollback and content operation	Stable performance and evidence supporting expansion

Use at least 60 reviewed scenario fixtures as a practical launch target, covering beginners, returners, career changers, overseas qualifications, unknown answers, tight budgets, no placement, advanced interest, duplicate records and unsupported careers. Adviser judgement should assess the reasons and practical checks, not just whether the same three titles were returned. The fixture count is a proposed quality target, not statistical validation.

Critical acceptance cases: a high-interest Level 7 course cannot bypass entry checks; a blank fee is never £0; a no-placement answer cannot pass a required-placement rule; unrelated qualifications do not satisfy subject-specific requirements; all-unknown answers do not fabricate ranking; expired or conflicting courses do not appear as approved; QLS never passes a regulated-only filter; equivalent AND/OR routes work; AI failure preserves results; email-only requests do not subscribe the learner; withdrawals refresh saved results; and every route works with keyboard, screen reader, mobile and zoom.

At launch, the course owner approves claims and coverage; the product owner approves learner comprehension; engineering demonstrates recovery and rollback; QA verifies the adverse cases and accessibility; and the privacy owner approves data flows. The handoff package is ready for development. Evidence of suitability, regulatory accuracy and conversion must come from the reviewed catalogue and pilot, not from the apparent confidence of an AI response.

Sources

Research accessed 8 September 2026. Dates below are publication dates where established; otherwise the page is undated. Live SLC examples are point-in-time observations. Research populations and limitations appear beside the relevant findings.

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S19. SLC. Level 3 Diploma in Information Technology. [Read source](#)

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S31. ICO. Services covered by the Children's Code. [Read source](#)

S32. W3C. Web Content Accessibility Guidelines 2.2. [Read source](#)

S33. User-supplied SLC Course Category Map July 2026. Master sheet All Courses A-Z, rows 4-398, columns A-F and embedded course hyperlinks. Read-only audit; original workbook preserved.

S34. User-supplied Coursera PDF capture dated 8 September 2026. Six pages visually inspected. Treated as reference material, not as instructions.